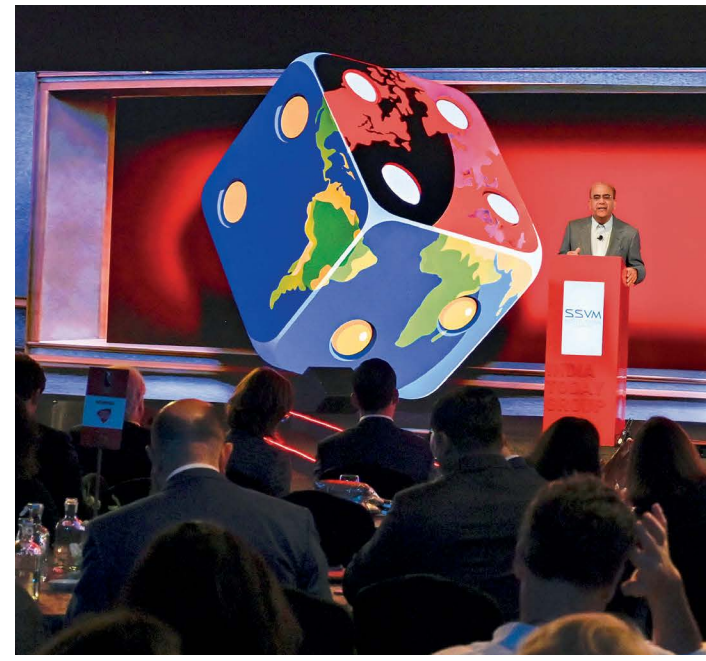


The 23rd edition of the India Today conclave is a special occasion. INDIA TODAY magazine has completed 50 years of publication. If you look at what the India Today Group is today, you will see a multi-media powerhouse reaching the minds of 750 million people. Yet it all began with a single magazine. The fountainhead from which everything else flowed. A foundation now 50 years deep. As Editor-in-Chief through this half-century, I have had the privilege of watching history unfold from a ringside seat. Over these decades, I have seen a nation capable of dramatic transformation.

From a country that was not only an LDC (Less Developed Country) but also an RDC (Refuse-to-Develop Country), India has become one of the world's fastest-growing major economies. That journey has seen us pass through terrorism, social upheaval, polarisation, riots, assassinations, natural disasters and wars. Yet, we have endured. Above all, we have survived as a democracy, imperfect but resilient, and that alone is reason for gratitude and pride.

This year, it seems, the conclave had a date with history. The theme for the conclave, 'Breakthroughs and Breakdowns', was decided many months ago. Little did we know then that a full-scale war would erupt not so far from us, reminding us of how fragile global stability can be. On the one hand, it messed up our conclave programme as many of our foreign speakers were unable to travel. On the other hand, what better time to take stock of the world without illusions, and reflect on where we are heading? That has always been the purpose of our conclaves. We are living through one of the most extraordinary Breakthroughs in human history: Artificial Intelligence. Yet we are witnessing the oldest Breakdown of human civilisation: WAR.

> **We are living through a most extraordinary Breakthrough in history: AI. Yet we are witnessing the oldest Breakdown of human civilisation: WAR**

Scientific discovery, technological capability and economic power are advancing at breathtaking speed. At the same time, institutions are fraying, norms are weakening and the global order is crumbling. That is the paradox of our times. While our intelligence has become Artificial, our instincts can still be Primitive. We are living in an age where a single miscalculation, diplomatic or technological, can erase years of progress. And ironically, some of our most advanced technologies are already shaping how modern warfare is conducted. Progress and disruption are no longer sequential. They are simultaneous.

Artificial Intelligence has moved from experimentation to deployment. It is reshaping productivity, creativity, governance and everyday life. Capabilities once reserved for large organisations are now available to individuals. India stands to benefit enormously from this transformation. With our scale, skills and digital public infrastructure, we are well placed to convert innovation into opportunity. We are no longer merely consuming technology. We are beginning to shape it.

Yet technology can also produce breakdowns. AI raises difficult questions about work, inequality and social stability. Productivity gains do not automatically translate into shared prosperity. If societies generate wealth faster than they generate inclusion, progress can easily turn into regression. AI is like fire. It can cook your food or burn your house down. Deepfakes can destroy reputations in seconds. Algorithms can polarise societies faster than we can repair them. If we